

(8.31—9.6)

【8.31| The Guardian】More than 3,000 high street firms appear to be shells laundering money

【Para.1】

Up to £464m has “moved through” more than 3,000 UK shell companies branded as beauty and convenience stores but apparently operating in the money-laundering and terrorist financing sectors, a new analysis sets out.

【Para.2】

The companies – some listed as hairdressers, barber shops and salons, others as mini-marts and corner shops – show “remarkably similar lifespans” of about six months despite their seemingly different purposes.

【Para.3】

They are also “heavily concentrated in a small number of areas”, according to the research by the anti-money-laundering software provider SmartSearch.

【Para.4】

The findings come amid increased scrutiny of the integrity of the UK company register, with many experts arguing that a proliferation of off-the-shelf businesses shows how bad actors are exploiting the system for money laundering and tax evasion.

【Para.5】

This month, Andy Burnham announced plans to give councils new powers to stop betting and vape shops taking over their high streets, while in May the government said a new specialist unit would target “dodgy” retail outlets such as vape stores and sweet shops that are suspected of being used to launder £1bn of criminal money.

【Para.6】

The topic was given more attention during a House of Commons Treasury committee meeting in June, when Paul Monaghan, the chief

executive of the Fair Tax Foundation, told MPs: “There is a reason that we have a company register full of hundreds of thousands of fraudsters.

【Para.7】

“The Insolvency Service has just recently shut down five illegal company service providers, which between them had set up 12,000 illegal companies in the UK, and we are only halfway through the year.

【Para.8】

“We have got a problem in this country that the obsession to set it up cheap and quick creates all the other problems.”

【Para.9】

The SmartSearch analysis of Companies House records between 2016 and 2026 focused solely on the two business sectors of beauty and convenience stores.

【Para.10】

It found 3,097 dissolved companies averaging 170 to 194 days of life, clustered into the same postcodes, the same registered addresses, and the same months of the year for incorporation and dissolution.

【Para.11】

The data also showed how 83% of suspect hairdressing companies and 92% of suspect convenience stores were incorporated in the first and second quarters of each year, with more than half dissolved in the fourth quarter.

【Para.12】

The cycle repeats annually across both sectors, the paper said, adding: “A single area of Cardiff contains 119 suspected companies on its own, across both sectors.”

【Para.13】

Phil Cotter, the chief executive of SmartSearch, said: “This is not a story about small businesses failing. It is a story about patterns that suggest a repeatable model of exploitation operating openly across UK high streets, and accelerating faster than the regulatory response has been able to catch. Companies House has made real progress since the

Economic Crime and Corporate Transparency Act came into force. But the register still reveals patterns that suggest the underlying activity is running ahead of the pace of reform.”

【Para.14】

The paper concludes: “The financial scale matters, and conservative modelling already suggests something between £310m and £464m has moved through these companies alone. Apply the same patterns across the other sectors named in the 2025 national risk assessment as high risk and the figure for the past decade likely sits above £1bn.”

25 August 2026 | The Guardian

正文字数：574 Words

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【9.1| The Guardian】Wildfires to rise by at least 39% in Europe by 2100 without action

【Para.1】

Wildfires are projected to burn 39% more of Europe by the end of the century even in the best-case scenario for stopping the planet from heating unless action is taken to manage them better, a study has found.

【Para.2】

The increase in hot, dry and windy weather that leads to small fires turning into raging infernos is to engulf more of Europe as carbon pollution pushes temperatures higher. In the worst-case scenario the researchers modelled, in which global heating would reach 3.6C above pre-industrial levels, the burnt area would almost triple.

【Para.3】

Improvements in fire management could moderate those increases by more than 70%, the study found, but not eradicate them entirely.

【Para.4】

“Investments into fire management could help to a certain limit, but if we go on a path of high emissions ... we still see strong increases in burnt area,” said Maik Billing, an ecosystem researcher at the Potsdam Institute for Climate Impact Research (PIK) and lead author of the study. “Fire management cannot replace climate mitigation.”

【Para.5】

The research comes as wildfires continue to ravage Europe, with large blazes hitting northern European countries such as the UK, Belgium and Germany after weeks in which France, Spain, Italy, Croatia and Greece battled monster infernos.

【Para.6】

Across the EU, this fire season is on course to become the third- worst on record, behind 2025 and 2022, according to data published by the European Forest Fire Information Service yesterday.

【Para.7】

More than 600,000 hectares have burned so far, with records broken for this time of year in Belgium, France and Slovakia.

【Para.8】

The researchers, who compared the projected annual burnt area in Europe in 2070-2100 with modelled results for the period from 2000 to 2030, found that the increase in fire weather was the biggest driver of change.

【Para.9】

In the optimistic scenario, in which global heating is capped at 1.8C above pre-industrial levels, a little above the current level of 1.4C, some regions showed moderate increases in fire weather while others experienced little change.

【Para.10】

In the pessimistic scenario, however, with 3.6C of heating by the end of the century, the researchers found consistent worsening of fire weather across “virtually all of Europe”.

【Para.11】

Scientists expect current policies to result in about 2.6C of global heating by the end of the century.

【Para.12】

Using a second model, the researchers found that continued improvements in fighting fires could temper the effects of worsening fire weather, reducing burnt area by 92% in the cooler scenario compared with firefighting efforts remaining at today's levels.

【Para.13】

The researchers used the Human Development Index as a proxy for firefighting ability, but acknowledged that the rise of mega-fires had made it hard to extrapolate from past experience.

【Para.14】

Improvements in fire suppression since the 1980s have reduced the number of fires and the area burnt in southern Europe, a study found this month, but the enthusiastic suppression of fires, even small ones, has paradoxically increased the residual fuel load.

【Para.15】

This has allowed fires to develop to extreme levels when conditions are favourable, resulting in fewer but more ferocious fires.

【Para.16】

Such monster fires hit France and Spain in late July this year, forcing a third of a million people from their homes as blazes raged with a force firefighters were unable to extinguish.

【Para.17】

Víctor Resco de Dios, a forestry engineer at the University of Lleida, who was not involved in the study, said the fire season was often accompanied by an “unproductive blame game” – isolating only one of the two key factors whose interaction results in wildfires – and that the study was a reminder to move beyond scapegoating.

【Para.18】

“The problem of wildfires wouldn’t be worsening if we were heading towards an ice age – instead of global warming,” he said. “And it would have been largely mitigated if our landscapes were like they were a century ago, with a much smaller forest area.”

21 August 2026 | The Guardian

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**【9.2| BARRON'S】Feeding AI: Data From A Bankrupt
Airline Is Now Worth Millions**

【Para.1】

The race to build the most advanced artificial-intelligence tools has spawned a new market for real world data. It comes with both opportunities and pitfalls for investors.

【Para.2】

Earlier this month, Google won an auction to purchase Spirit Airlines' software code, internal messages, and financial and operational data for \$10 million, according to filings from Spirit's bankruptcy proceedings. Google hopes to use the data to improve its products and AI models, a spokesperson said.

【Para.3】

That \$10 million outlay for a busted airline's data is just the tip of the iceberg. AI companies are vacuuming up corporate information of all sorts—a process that has taken on greater importance now that scraping the internet has become more legally fraught.

【Para.4】

The demand for data is linked to how AI large-language models are created and refined. The computer systems ingest huge volumes of human information and use it to mimic human processes, such as writing reports, interpreting and responding to messages, and making recommendations. More data means more examples the model can pull from.

【Para.5】

In response, public companies are weighing whether to license their data. And start-ups are opening marketplaces through which smaller enterprises can sell everything from contracts to email threads.

【Para.6】

“Companies are sitting on decades of records that show how real work gets done, and that data is now some of the most valuable material for training and evaluating AI,” said a spokesperson from Mercor, an AI data start-up that made a \$7.5 million bid in the Spirit auction.

【Para.7】

The economics make perfect sense. The five largest cloud providers are spending a combined \$800 billion in capital expenditures in 2026 to build data centers, and AI labs are paying hundreds of billions to use the facilities. Millions of dollars—with an “M”—mean very little to them when creating new AI tools, but that money can be a game-changer for data sellers.

【Para.8】

The market appears to be picking up. In January, Cloudflare acquired HumanNative, a marketplace connecting content creators with

AI developers. Two months later, News Corp, the owner of Barron's publisher Dow Jones, struck a licensing deal with Meta Platforms, where the publisher sold access to its content for \$50 million a year.

【Para.9】

For smaller companies and even individuals looking to sell their data, an array of start-ups are emerging to broker deals.

【Para.10】

Over a recent 11-day stretch, micro1, an AI data venture, committed more than \$20 million to license operational data, said CEO Ali Ansari in a social media post this past week.

【Para.11】

Investors can get in on the action, too. Barron's made two stock picks last month based on the growing value of AI training data.

【Para.12】

Reddit struck agreements with OpenAI and Google in 2024 to license conversations from its forums, bringing in an estimated \$60

million a year from each lab. The social-media platform is now in negotiations with Google, and some investors and analysts expect a much larger deal.

【Para.13】

John Wiley & Sons, a publisher of academic and technical literature, has also racked up big-name customers. The company's licensing agreements with leading AI developers have generated more than \$110 million since 2024. It also has collaborations with Amazon Web Services, Microsoft, Anthropic, and others.

【Para.14】

The key for investors, and indeed companies, is pinpointing when data sales may do more harm than good.

【Para.15】

Privacy is one challenge, particularly for consumer-facing businesses. Opera, the Norwegian web-browser company, has resisted selling data on those grounds.

【Para.16】

“If we lose the users’ trust, if they think, ‘Oh, if we use the Opera browser, then they’re actually going to sell our data,’ then it’s probably not a wise move,” said Frode Jacobsen, chief financial officer at Opera, at an investor conference in January.

【Para.17】

Disruption by AI is the other threat. If the labs use a company’s proprietary information to build something better, or at least more popular, they could siphon away demand.

【Para.18】

“Our data is really the crown jewels of the future,” said Gary Morrison, CEO of hostel booking platform Hostelworld Group, in a conference call last month. “It is everything that we know about profiles, about bookings, about events, about people you’re meeting, what you’re talking about.”

【Para.19】

But companies like Hostelworld, and indeed Reddit and John Wiley, will have to survive in an AI-dominated world whether they like it or not.

That means many more executives will have to decide how much “the crown jewels” are worth.

August 24, 2026 | BARRON’S

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【9.3| Economist】Frozen fish

How salmon evolved to cope with the ice age

【Para.1】

Some species thrived during the last ice age. Sabre-toothed cats, giant ground sloths, woolly mammoths and woolly rhinos all did pretty well. Others, however, were seriously inconvenienced—among them the chum salmon of north-western North America, which frequently found

the rivers leading to and from their inland spawning grounds icebound.

【Para.2】

For those cut off in the sea, this was a nuisance. They had to make alternative arrangements, by seeking other, more accessible bodies of fresh water in which to lay their eggs. Those cut off on the land side, though, were stuck. And it was assumed until recently that because they were unable to complete the marine part of their life-cycle, they died out.

【Para.3】

Not so, it turns out. A study published recently in *Quaternary Research* by Patrick Martin, an avid fisherman with a sideline as an amateur scientist, has employed genetics to show that some of the left-behinds not only endured, but thrived.

【Para.4】

Pacific chum salmon range around that ocean's rim from Japan and the Koreas to the coast of Oregon. Naturally, there is genetic variation in such a widespread population. Some of this variation is, though, so extreme that it has left researchers baffled. Three particular hot spots are around Kodiak island and nearby Cook inlet, in Alaska, and in the Salish sea between British Columbia and Washington state.

【Para.5】

Intriguingly, it is not only the fishes' genetics that differ, but also their behaviours. Most salmon migrate from the sea into fresh water to spawn in autumn or winter. The Salish sea population does so in summer. Similarly, salmon generally spawn in rivers. One of the Cook inlet populations, by contrast, does so in a lake.

【Para.6】

Isolation over periods of thousands of years is well understood to drive evolution. This is obvious on small islands, such as the Galápagos. But walls of ice can isolate, too. With this in mind, Mr Martin speculated that the Kodiak, Cook and Salish salmon are genetically different from their neighbours because they got trapped, and survived, in glacial lakes.

【Para.7】

Between 23,000 and 15,000 years ago glaciers created a lake on Kodiak island, with an area of 1,000 square kilometres and a depth of 300 metres. Glacial lakes also formed in valleys around the Olympic mountains of modern-day Washington state. To test his hunch, Mr Martin therefore convened a team of ichthyologists and geologists from the University of Washington and America's National Oceanic and

Atmospheric Administration to analyse the genes of 32,817 specimens from 310 populations around the Pacific rim.

【Para.8】

One question that needed an answer was whether the unusual genetics could be explained by a few salmon from Asia having taken a wrong turn and introduced their DNA into their North American cousins. The aberrant populations, however, bore no close relation to their Asian kin. Instead, the team proposes that the ancestors of these survived the ice age isolated in freshwater lakes, where they went their own sweet evolutionary ways.

【Para.9】

During this period, Mr Martin and his colleagues argue, the fish rejigged their behaviour to treat the lakes they were trapped in like miniature oceans, complete with migrating up glacial streams feeding the lakes to spawn. That rejigging then persisted, at least in part, when the ice dams melted and the fish were liberated into the sea.

【Para.10】

At least some of chum salmon's genetic peculiarities are thus, presumably, the drivers of their unusual behaviours. But others could be

relics of physiological adaptations to the stress of a life confined to fresh water in a species that normally spends much of its existence in the briny. That is of interest to evolutionary biologists. It may also intrigue conservationists, for genetic diversity is a good insurance against extinction and these odd salmon populations have diversity in spades. And fish farmers may take notice as well, if they are thinking about trying to raise salmon in colder waters or even freshwater lakes, where sea lice are absent and infectious pathogens less common.

August 29TH- September 4TH | Science & technology

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【9.4| Economist】Marching across borders

Why smugglers are stealing Kenya's ants

【Para.1】

It was a smuggling operation to make your skin crawl. At Nairobi airport earlier this year, Kenyan authorities discovered more than 2,200 African harvester ants hidden in a man's luggage. Most were packed inside small plastic tubes plugged with damp cotton, designed to keep the ants alive for weeks while they made it to their recipients, collectors in China. In April the smuggler was sentenced to a year in prison. His conviction followed a series of similar cases, including the arrest last year of two Belgian teenagers carrying around 5,000 ants.

【Para.2】

A global craze for pet ants has fuelled a booming black market in live queen ants. An African harvester queen can sell for more than \$200 in the black market (it costs barely \$3 in Kenya). The country has become a hub for illegal trading because it has abundant populations of the species, alongside established smuggling networks that have long trafficked wildlife.

【Para.3】

Ant-keeping became a popular pastime during the pandemic as people searched for indoor hobbies. Enthusiasts keep colonies in transparent formicariums—miniature “ant cities”—where they watch the

insects dig tunnels and forage for food. Social media has helped turn the pastime into a global phenomenon. YouTube channels such as AntsCanada, which has more than 7m subscribers, narrate the stories of individual colonies like nature documentaries, from queens founding new nests to battles with rival species.

【Para.4】

Most ant-keeping is perfectly legal. Specialist dealers breed the insects and sell them in licensed shops. But demand for rare and exotic ants has outpaced legal supply. African harvester ants are especially prized because they are among the world's largest ant species and display complex social behaviours, making them “the tigers of the ant world”, says Dino Martins, an entomologist and evolutionary biologist based in Kenya.

【Para.5】

Scientists worry that removing large numbers of ants could damage Kenyan ecosystems. Traffickers target queens because each colony has just one breeding female. She typically lives for 25 years and can produce a colony of thousands of workers. Ants play a crucial role in east Africa's savannahs. As they forage, they collect and disperse grass seeds, helping maintain the diverse grasslands on which much wildlife depends. The

ants' vast underground nests add oxygen to the soil and create nutrient-rich hotspots where plants grow more easily. Meanwhile many other animals, such as pangolins, feast on the ants themselves.

【Para.6】

Authorities are scrambling to stop the illegal exodus. Kenya Wildlife Service has pushed for tougher penalties and stepped up inspections at airports. But conservationists say the recent seizures are probably only the tip of the anthill. And interceptions address the trade only after the damage has been done. Alongside tougher enforcement, Mr Martins argues, authorities should educate collectors and local communities about the insects' ecological importance. Unless demand falls, smugglers will find new ways to keep ants marching across borders.

August 29TH- September 4TH | Middle East & Africa

正文字数: 495 words

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【9.5| Economist】Film-going frenzy

China's latest cash cow is a clunky cartoon bull

【Para.1】

To many grown-ups, the cartoon film “Niu Lai” would be 86 minutes of torture. Yet in recent days cinemas across China have been packed with older audiences happily enduring its crudely animated depiction of a bullock’s dream about motherly love and threatening predators. No matter that the film is excruciatingly slow-paced, with long seconds of silence as its characters merely blink. On a typical day in late August earnings at the box office were the seventh highest in China, just behind a new Hollywood blockbuster, “Spider-Man: Brand New Day”. The cartoon has become a meme-driven frenzy.

【Para.2】

Western audiences have turned trashy films into cult classics: “The Room”, an American film released in 2003, became so notorious for its bad acting and appalling script and set design that audiences flocked to see it for laughs. “Niu Lai”, which is the bullock’s name (it means “the bull is coming”), has a similar attraction: a copy of it on YouTube,

apparently filmed in a Chinese cinema with a mobile phone, drew more than 1.1m views before being deleted. The chuckles of the Chinese audience (the film is not supposed to be funny) are clearly audible.

【Para.3】

Yet in a country where, unlike in Western countries, the government plays a big role in making, financing and shaping the narratives of films, the popularity of “Niu Lai”—an independent production by a mother-and-son team on a shoestring budget—is a remarkable phenomenon. Young people have flooded China’s social media with comments that often go beyond mere catcalling. On Weibo, one of the most popular platforms, posts with the hashtag “Niu Lai” have been viewed more than 170m times: well over the count (100m) for the hashtag of China’s currently hottest movie: “Once Upon a Time in the Middle East”. That one is a big-budget state-backed film that officials have been organising people to watch because of its heart-warming tale of a Chinese cook’s heroism amid a destructive American invasion of an Iraq-like country.

【Para.4】

Despite deliberate seat-packing, the number-one film does appear to be genuinely popular. But online commenters use “Niu Lai” in order to

poke at the industry's pouring money into films that aim to spread the Communist Party's messages; they use star actors but are often second-rate. Viewers carp at online censors' habit of suppressing negative views of these party-backed extravaganzas. "Anyone can point at 'Niu Lai' and call it trash," wrote one Weibo user to his more than 1.5m followers, echoing a commonly expressed view. "But those beautifully packaged, mega-budget super-flops in the film industry—are we even allowed to criticise them?...Absolutely not. That's why they aren't even as good as 'Niu Lai'."

【Para.5】

Discomfiting though such commentary must be for officials, the phenomenon may have upsides for the government. Some netizens have poached the cartoon's imagery to produce mini-videos suggesting that a bull run in the stock market is on its way. Officials love to promote optimism about the country's faltering economy. Amid the bull craze, censors are standing back.

August 29TH- September 4TH | China

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【9.6| Economist】Dead wait

The problem with the world's oldest mummies

【Para.1】

Running 600km along the coast of the Atacama desert, from southern Peru to northern Chile, is a mass-burial site for the world's oldest mummies. The Chinchorro, who lived on the strip of coast from 7000BC to 1000bc, and survived by hunting and fishing, were meticulous preservers of their dead. Almost everyone who died could be mummified, with no regard for social status. This, combined with the dry environment of the Atacama, has led to an odd situation: the world's oldest deliberately preserved bodies are so numerous that they are creating problems.

【Para.2】

Lately, more bodies have been emerging from the earth. César Borie is an archaeologist with Chinchorro Marka, an agency that Chile's

government has charged with the protection of the country's Chinchorro archaeological sites. He studies a skeleton that he stumbled upon while walking around Caleta Camarones, a town near the city of Arica in northern Chile. "We find new remains exposed every time we come here," he says, gently reburying the bones with his hands. "Keeping them under the soil until the conditions are right is the best we can do."

【Para.3】

This is not a new phenomenon. Chinchorro mummies have been issuing from the ground since at least the early 20th century. Initial expeditions in 1917 transported mummies to museums around Chile, where experts preserved them for study. Archeologists also ran excavations until the 1990s.

【Para.4】

But erosion caused by extreme winds and increasing human activity nearby has been accelerating the mummies' exposure. The region has run out of space to receive the bodies and keep them preserved. It would take hundreds of trucks to distribute them all, says Mr Borie. "There is nowhere to keep the mummies in museums without exposing them to damaging light and temperatures," says Veronica Silva, an anthropologist at the Natural History Museum in Santiago, Chile's capital.

【Para.5】

And so archaeologists keen to learn more about the Chinchorro's months-long mummification rituals are having to study the bodies in situ, reburying them when they are finished. "Until we have the right technology, we prefer keeping them underground instead of excavating more," says Camila Castillo, also of Chinchorro Marka. A new museum that is under construction south of Arica should help.

【Para.6】

In 2021 UNESCO added the Chinchorro remains and their landscape to its list of world heritage sites. That presented a possible solution: developing the sites into a tourist attraction, and hosting many of the mummies there. But not everyone is happy with that. A small fishing community has illegally built makeshift homes in the Camerones valley within the site. UNESCO would like them to relocate, but they are not so keen. Meanwhile their numbers are growing, and their presence is increasingly damaging the remains.

【Para.7】

The local mayor, Christian Zavala, has upped the tension by saying the mummies get more attention than his constituents. But some older

residents like José Concha, who has lived in the area for more than 30 years, understand the economic opportunities they offer. “I’m becoming too old to go fishing,” he says. “I would love to become a tour guide to teach tourists about the mummies.”

【Para.8】

Ms Castillo says Chinchorro Marka hopes to raise money to set up a centre where the mummies can be studied and exhibited in collaboration with residents of Camarones. But if that is to work, the archaeologists will need to show that they care as much about Caleta Camarones’s future as they do about its past.

August 29TH- September 4TH | The Americas

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